EGGLESS CHOCOLATE TRES LECHES CAKE

A deeply chocolatey, milk-soaked sponge with silky chocolate mascarpone icing and glossy dark chocolate ganache.

THE CURLY CHEF • DETAILED RECIPE

Yield: 1 single, thick square cake • 9 portions
Baking pan: 20 × 20 cm
Oven: 170°C conventional / 160°C fan
Active preparation: 60–75 minutes
Chilling: minimum 6 hours; overnight preferred

IMPORTANT: This is one single sponge—not a stacked or horizontally layered cake. The finished cake has one continuous sponge, chocolate mascarpone icing on top and ganache poured over it.

1. Ingredients

Weigh ingredients accurately. Use a digital scale for reliable results. Ingredients should be at room temperature unless stated otherwise.

A. Eggless chocolate sponge

Ingredient	Weight
Plain flour	150 g
Dutch-process cocoa powder	25 g
Caster sugar	145 g
Baking powder	5 g
Baking soda	2 g
Fine salt	1.5 g
Plain full-fat yoghurt	120 g
Whole milk	150 g
Neutral oil (sunflower/canola)	55 g
Vanilla extract	5 g
White vinegar (add last)	8 g

B. Chocolate tres leches soak

Ingredient	Weight
Sweetened condensed milk	200 g
Evaporated milk	250 g
Whole milk	150 g
Dutch-process cocoa powder	12 g
Dark chocolate, 55–65%, chopped	45 g
Fine salt	0.5 g
Vanilla extract	3 g

C. Chocolate mascarpone icing

Ingredient	Weight
Cold whipping cream, 35% fat	250 g
Cold mascarpone	100 g
Icing sugar	20 g
Dutch-process cocoa powder	10 g
Dark chocolate, melted and cooled to 28–30°C	35 g
Vanilla extract	3 g

D. Glossy chocolate ganache

Ingredient	Weight
Dark chocolate, 55–65%, finely chopped	120 g
Whipping cream, 35% fat	120 g
Unsalted butter (optional, extra sheen)	8 g

2. Equipment

- 20 × 20 cm square baking pan, parchment paper for baking only.
- Digital scale, bowls, whisk, spatula, sieve and offset spatula.
- Small jug or ladle, skewer, saucepan and heatproof bowl.
- Flat serving board or plate. After baking, remove the sponge from the pan and peel off all parchment before soaking and decorating.

3. Eggless chocolate sponge

1. Prepare the pan. Heat oven to 170°C conventional (160°C fan). Line the base and sides of the 20 × 20 cm pan with parchment.

2. Mix wet ingredients. In a large bowl, whisk yoghurt and sugar until smooth. Whisk in milk, oil and vanilla.

3. Sift in dry ingredients. Sift flour, cocoa, baking powder, baking soda and salt directly into the same bowl. Fold with a spatula until no dry pockets remain. Scrape the bottom and sides; do not beat vigorously.

4. Add vinegar last. Add the vinegar and fold briefly until incorporated. Put the batter in the oven promptly because the leavening reaction has started.

5. Bake. Level batter gently. Bake approximately 25–32 minutes. Start checking at 25 minutes. A skewer should come out without raw batter; a few moist crumbs are fine. The centre should spring back lightly.

6. Cool and unmould. Rest 10–15 minutes, remove the sponge from the pan, peel away parchment and cool completely on a rack. Place the single, uncut sponge on a flat serving board or plate.

4. Chocolate tres leches soak

1. Make cocoa paste. Whisk cocoa powder with a little of the measured whole milk to form a smooth paste and prevent lumps.

2. Warm the milks. Add cocoa paste, condensed milk, evaporated milk, remaining whole milk and salt to a saucepan. Heat gently, whisking, until steaming. Do not boil.

3. Melt chocolate. Remove from heat. Add chopped chocolate, wait 30–60 seconds, then whisk until smooth. Stir in vanilla. Cool until warm but fluid.

4. Puncture sponge. Make evenly spaced holes across the cooled sponge with a skewer, deep enough for liquid to travel into the cake without tearing it.

5. Soak gradually. Pour over the sponge in three additions, pausing about 2 minutes between additions. Distribute liquid across the surface and edges. If liquid pools heavily, pause rather than forcing it all in.

6. Chill. Cover and refrigerate for at least 6 hours, preferably overnight. The sponge should be thoroughly chilled and the soak distributed before icing.

5. Chocolate mascarpone icing

1. Cool chocolate. Melt the 35 g dark chocolate gently and cool to 28–30°C. It should remain fluid but not hot.

2. Whip. In a cold bowl, whisk cold cream, mascarpone, icing sugar, cocoa and vanilla to soft peaks. Stop before it becomes grainy.

3. Temper and fold. Mix a spoonful of whipped cream into the melted chocolate to loosen it. Fold this back into the remaining cream until evenly chocolate-coloured and silky. Avoid vigorous mixing.

4. Ice. Spread icing directly over the chilled, soaked, single-piece sponge with an offset spatula. Do not split or stack the cake.

6. Glossy chocolate ganache

1. Heat cream. Warm the cream until steaming around the edges; do not boil hard.

2. Make ganache. Pour hot cream over chopped chocolate. Leave for 1 minute, then stir slowly from the centre outward until smooth and glossy. Add butter, if using, after the emulsion is smooth.

3. Cool to pouring consistency. Let the ganache cool until fluid but not hot, often around 30–32°C depending on the chocolate and room temperature. Too hot can melt the icing; too cool will not flow.

4. Pour. Pour a ribbon over the centre of the iced cake. Guide towards the edges with a small spatula, allowing a few natural drips. Use enough to coat without necessarily hiding all the icing.

5. Set and serve. Refrigerate 20–40 minutes until set. For neat slices, use a long sharp knife warmed in hot water and wiped dry between cuts.

7. Troubleshooting

Problem	Likely cause / solution
Dense or gummy sponge	Overmixing, inaccurate leavening or underbaking. Fold only until combined and check the centre.
Soak pools on top	Pour more slowly in stages and pause between additions. Absorption varies with the sponge.
Grainy icing	Cream overwhipped or chocolate temperature unsuitable. Stop at soft peaks and temper chocolate with a spoonful of cream first.
Ganache melts icing	It was too warm. Cool until fluid but only gently warm before pouring.
Ganache too thick	Warm gently in short bursts or over a warm-water bath, stirring until pourable.
Cake crumbles when cut	It may be over-soaked or insufficiently chilled. Chill overnight and use a warm, clean knife.

8. Storage and food safety

- Keep covered and refrigerated at 4°C or below because the cake contains dairy and a milk soak.
- For best quality, consume within 3 days. Do not leave at room temperature for more than 2 hours in total; less in a hot environment.
- Transport chilled. For the cleanest finish, pour ganache only after the icing has chilled and set slightly.

Final professional checklist

- One single, uncut sponge; parchment fully removed before soaking.
- Soak poured gradually; cake thoroughly chilled.
- Icing smooth and stable; applied only on top.
- Ganache cooled to a pourable temperature, not hot.
- Clean serving board; use a warm, dry knife for slicing.

The Curly Chef • Eggless baking, crafted with precision.